

## METHODOLOGY

## How the Ranking was Done

To conduct the annual survey of academic excellence in India in the arts, science, commerce, law, engineering and medicine streams, INDIA TODAY commissioned AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG. To determine the ranking, an AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG team, comprising Ram Mohan Dhara, Deep Chowdhury, Mani Gupta and Maria Rani Tirkey, worked on a formula based on a perception score (from an opinion poll conducted among academic experts) and an objective score (factual data furnished by colleges).

Desk research was conducted to generate the list of colleges for the survey and secondary data sources, like the Internet, published reports and the Association of Indian Universities Handbook, were used. Suggestions from experts were also taken into account. A comprehensive list of over 1,400 colleges was drawn up. To calculate the final score, over 1,100 experts—principals, heads of departments and deans in 12 cities, Ahmedabad, Bangalore, Chandigarh, Chennai, Kochi, Delhi, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai and Pune—were approached in March and April.

After working out the familiarity quotient, the respondents were asked to distribute 100 points across seven vital parameters: reputation of the college, curriculum, quality of academic input, student care, admission procedure, infrastructure and job prospects. The most important parameter got the maximum point and the least, the minimum. Each expert rated colleges in his or her field only. A statistical equation was used to calculate the overall perceptual score. Experts' responses on their own colleges were excluded to minimise bias. Factual data was then collected for colleges that had received the top perceptual ratings. For factual ranking, all the parameters were rescaled to get a single score. To calculate the overall score, 70:30 weightages were assigned to perceptual and factual scores, respectively—the rationale being consistency with the previous year's study. This methodology of ranking, based on both perceptual and factual data, provides a comprehensive picture of each college rated.

This year, the survey has ranked the Top 50 colleges in arts, commerce and science and the Top 25 colleges in medicine, engineering and law.

Kolkata, Chennai, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Ahmedabad, Chandigarh, Pune and Lucknow. This resulted in the emergence of a host of new winners, with even non-metro colleges pushing their way into the honours list.

On the other hand, the exercise of collecting data and calculating the ranks, normally a complex process, was made even more so. With more than 18,064 colleges and 369 universities spread across the country, short-listing colleges to a manageable size is always a difficult task. As in the past, INDIA TODAY commissioned AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG, the country's premier polling agency, to conduct the survey on its behalf. Building on the database collected over the years, bolstered by interviews with experts and scrutiny of reports from the

Association of Indian Universities, among others, the polling agency drew up a list of 1,400 colleges.

To home in on the best of these, representatives of the agency approached 360 experts, comprising principals, heads of departments and deans, across the 12 cities and from the six streams to shortlist 600 colleges based on their perception. Another 540 experts across the same spectrum were then interviewed to rank the colleges on the basis of seven key parameters, including reputation of the college, infrastructure and job placement. Relying on the per-

ceptual score accorded by the experts, 270 colleges across all six streams were selected.

To back the findings, factual data was collected from these colleges and scores allotted. Colleges that did not provide the team factual data needed for the assessment were not considered for the final rankings. To calculate the overall rankings, a weightage of 70:30 was assigned to perceptual and factual scores (see box above).

Since the survey is heavily weighted in favour of the perceptions of experts, colleges that make it a point to expose their innovations and

Colleges that expose their achievements to peer review are better placed to improve their rankings

